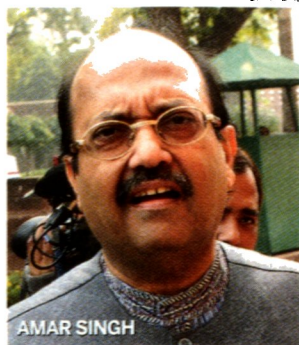


DELHI | The Sharing Game

The proposed Congress-sp alliance for seat-sharing in Uttar Pradesh seems caught in a personality war between two of the chief negotiators—Congress General Secretary Digvijay Singh and sp leader Amar Singh. The talks began with bonhomie as Mulayam Singh Yadav joked to Rahul Gandhi, “Which is the third seat you want?” It was a clear indication that the Gandhi bastions of Amethi and Rae Bareilly were of course given. But scared that the sp may think this to be a walk over, Digvijay has upped the ante warning that the Congress was not standing with a begging bowl. The Congress wants 20 seats while the sp is offering 15.



AMAR SINGH



DIGVIJAY SINGH

It's a negotiating tactic with Digvijay playing the 'tough guy' while Rahul and the prime minister woo Amar Singh. Manmohan Singh does not want any acrimony during the session. Then the political see-saw begins again. *by Priya Sahgal*

In the Air

Air fares are going up, passenger loads are coming down and airlines are deep in the red. Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel nevertheless goes around inaugurating airports as if they were ration shops. In the last 10 days, he has opened eight of them. No fear of flying for this minister.

by Amitabh Srivastava

PATNA | Poll Stop

Murder convict and MP Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav may be a free bird now after securing bail from the Patna High Court. But he can't contest the Lok Sabha polls because the Representation of People Act stipulates that a convict (awarded imprisonment of two years or more) is ineligible to contest elections unless his conviction, not just the sentence, is stayed by a higher court. The same goes for LJP MP Surajbhan Singh, RJD MP Mohammad Shahabuddin and former MP Anand Mohan—they can't contest as they are also serving life sentences.

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